

Zachary Nolan Sunberg

Ann and H. J. Smead Aerospace Engineering Sciences
University of Colorado Boulder
720-933-7799 • zachary.sunberg@colorado.edu • zachary.sunberg.net

Academic Appointments

Assistant Professor [January 2020 – Present]
University of Colorado, Boulder, CO
Ann and H. J. Smead Aerospace Engineering Sciences Department
Computer Science Department, by courtesy

Postdoctoral Research Scholar [October 2018 – October 2019]
University of California, Berkeley, CA
Supervisor: Claire Tomlin, Hybrid Systems Laboratory

Education

Doctor of Philosophy in Aeronautics and Astronautics [2018]
Stanford University, Stanford, CA
Advisor: Mykel Kochenderfer | Thesis: "Safety and Efficiency in Autonomous Vehicles through Planning with Uncertainty"

Master of Science in Aerospace Engineering [2013]
Texas A&M University, College Station, TX
Advisor: Jonathan Rogers | Thesis: "A Real Time Expert Control System for Helicopter Autorotation"

Bachelor of Science in Aerospace Engineering [2011]
Texas A&M University, College Station, TX
Summa cum Laude, Minor in Mathematics

Industry Experience

Google, Inc., Mountain View, CA [Summer 2014]
Software Engineering Intern
Evaluated and optimized a NASA collision avoidance program for use with Google self-piloted air vehicles.

Lockheed Martin Autonomous Systems, Littleton, CO [Summer 2009]
Engineering Intern
Helped in testing of autonomous SMSS allterrain military transport vehicle navigation system; wrote rough terrain navigation program in C++ based on the A* search algorithm; wrote software in C++ for analyzing the performance of an advanced video analysis tool.

Awards and Fellowships

Smead Aerospace Engineering Department Outstanding Junior Faculty Award [2025]
NSF CAREER Award [2024]
IET Cyberphysical Systems Journal Premium Paper Award [2023]
AIAA Journal of Guidance, Control, and Dynamics Excellent Reviewer [2021,2022]
IJCAI 2019 Distinguished Program Committee member [2019]
Association for the Advancement of Artificial Intelligence (AAAI) Doctoral Consortium [2018]
National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship [2012-2016]

Publications

My name and the names of my students are indicated with bold font.

Peer Reviewed Journal Articles

- [J1] [Under Review] **Ofer Dagan**, **Tyler Becker**, and **Zachary N. Sunberg**. “Hypothesis-Driven Sensor Tasking for Space Domain Awareness”. In: *The Journal of the Astronautical Sciences* (2026)
- [J2] [Under Review] **Austin Monell** and **Zachary Sunberg**. “Trajectory Optimization and Performance of a V-Twin Airborne Wind Energy System”. In: *Wind Energy Science* (2026)
- [J3] [In Revision] **Benjamin D. Kraske**, **Qi Heng Ho**, **Federico Rossi**, **Morteza Lahijanani**, and **Zachary Sunberg**. “Robustness of POMDP Policies to Observation Perturbations”. In: *Journal of Artificial Intelligence Research* (2026)
- [J4] [In Revision] **Mark Boyer**, **Adrian Robinson**, **Torin K. Clark**, and **Zachary Sunberg**. “Comprehensive Evaluation of Explanation Types in a Spaceflight-Relevant Human-Autonomy Teaming Task”. In: *IEEE Transactions on Human Factors and Ergonomics* (2026)
- [J5] **Prashin Sharma**, **Benjamin Kraske**, **Joseph Kim**, **Zakariya Laouar**, **Ella Atkins**, and **Zachary Sunberg**. “Risk-Aware Markov Decision Process Contingency Management Autonomy for Uncrewed Aircraft Systems”. In: *AIAA Journal of Aerospace Information Systems (JAIS)* 21.3 (2024). doi: 10.2514/1.1011235. URL: [🔗](#)
- [J6] **Qi Heng Ho**, **Zachary N. Sunberg**, and **Morteza Lahijanani**. “Sampling-based Reactive Synthesis for Nondeterministic Hybrid Systems”. In: *Robotics and Automation Letters (RA-L)* 9.2 (2024). doi: 10.1109/LRA.2023.3340029. URL: [🔗](#)
- [J7] **Michael H. Lim**, **Tyler J. Becker**, **Mykel J. Kochenderfer**, **Claire J. Tomlin**, and **Zachary N. Sunberg**. “Optimality Guarantees for Particle Belief Approximation of POMDPs”. In: *Journal of Artificial Intelligence Research* 77 (2023). doi: 10.1613/jair.1.14525. URL: [🔗](#)
- [J8] **Benjamin W. Blonder**, **Michael H. Lim**, **Zachary Sunberg**, and **Claire Tomlin**. “Navigation between initial and desired community states using shortcuts”. In: *Ecology Letters* 26.4 (2023). doi: 10.1111/ele.14171. URL: [🔗](#)
- [J9] **Zachary Sunberg** and **Mykel Kochenderfer**. “Improving Automated Driving through Planning with Human Internal States”. In: *IEEE Transactions on Intelligent Transportation Systems* 23.11 (2022). doi: 10.1109/TITS.2022.3182687. URL: [🔗](#)
- [J10] **Shakeeb Ahmad**, **Zachary N. Sunberg**, and **J. Sean Humbert**. “End-to-End Probabilistic Depth Perception and 3D Obstacle Avoidance using POMDP”. In: *Journal of Intelligent & Robotic Systems* 103.2 (2021), pp. 1–18. doi: 10.1007/s10846-021-01489-w
- [J11] **Patrick Slade**, **Zachary Sunberg**, and **Mykel J. Kochenderfer**. “Estimation and Control Using Sampling-Based Bayesian Reinforcement Learning”. In: *IET Cyber-Physical Systems: Theory and Applications* 5 (1 2020). doi: 10.1049/iet-cps.2019.0045. URL: [🔗](#)
- [J12] **Maxim Egorov**, **Zachary N. Sunberg**, **Edward Balaban**, **Tim A. Wheeler**, **Jayesh K. Gupta**, and **Mykel J. Kochenderfer**. “POMDPs.jl: A Framework for Sequential Decision Making under Uncertainty”. In: *Journal of Machine Learning Research* 18.26 (2017), pp. 1–5. URL: [🔗](#)
- [J13] **Zachary Sunberg**, **Suman Chakravorty**, and **Richard Scott Erwin**. “Information Space Receding Horizon Control for Multisensor Tasking Problems”. In: *IEEE Transactions on Cybernetics* 46.6 (2016), pp. 1325–1336. URL: [🔗](#)
- [J14] **Zachary N. Sunberg**, **Nathaniel R. Miller**, and **Jonathan D. Rogers**. “A Real-Time Expert Control System For Helicopter Autorotation”. In: *Journal of the American Helicopter Society* 60.2 (2015), pp. 1–15. ISSN: 2161-6027. doi: 10.4050/JAHS.60.022008. URL: [🔗](#)
- [J15] **Zachary Sunberg**, **Suman Chakravorty**, and **Richard Scott Erwin**. “Information Space Receding Horizon Control”. In: *IEEE Transactions on Cybernetics* 43.6 (2013), pp. 2255–2260. doi: 10.1109/TSMCB.2012.2236313. URL: [🔗](#)

- [J16] **Zachary Sunberg** and Jonathan Rogers. “A Belief Function Distance Metric for Orderable Sets”. In: *Information Fusion* 14.4 (2013), pp. 361–373. ISSN: 1566-2535. DOI: 10.1016/J.INFFUS.2013.03.003. URL: [🔗](#)

Peer Reviewed Journal-Equivalent Conference Publications.....

Journal-equivalent conference publications have rigorous peer review of the entire article, an acceptance rate of approximately 30% or less, and are recognized to be as important as journal papers in the field.

- [JC1] [Under Review] **Lisa Ventura**, **Tyler Becker**, and **Zachary Sunberg**. “Constraint Budget Allocation in Multiagent MDPs”. In: *Robotics: Science and Systems (RSS)*. 2026
- [JC2] [Under Review] **Himanshu Gupta**, Paul Motter, Bradley Hayes, and **Zachary Sunberg**. “Efficient Multi-Robot Motion Planning with Precomputed Translation-Invariant Edge Bundles”. In: *Robotics: Science and Systems (RSS)*. 2026
- [JC3] [Accepted, Awaiting Publication] **Mel Krusniak**, **Ofer Dagan**, **Himanshu Gupta**, **Benjamin Kraske**, Kyle Hollins Wray, and **Zachary Sunberg**. “Decisions.jl: Representing and Transforming Decision Problem Classes in Julia”. In: *Autonomous Agents and Multi-Agent Systems (AAMAS)*. 2026
- [JC4] [Accepted, Awaiting Publication] **Zakariya Laouar**, **Qi Heng Ho**, and **Zachary N. Sunberg**. “Leveraging the Value of Information in POMDP Planning”. In: *International Conference on Automated Planning and Scheduling (ICAPS)*. 2026
- [JC5] **Qi Heng Ho**, **Tyler Becker**, **Benjamin Kraske**, **Zakariya Laouar**, Martin S. Feather, Federico Rossi, Morteza Lahijanian, and **Zachary N. Sunberg**. “Recursively-Constrained Markov Decision Processes”. In: *The 40th Conference on Uncertainty in Artificial Intelligence*. 2024. URL: [🔗](#)
- [JC6] **Qi Heng Ho**, Martin S. Feather, Federico Rossi, **Zachary N. Sunberg**, and Morteza Lahijanian. “Sound Heuristic Search Value Iteration for Undiscounted POMDPs with Reachability Objectives”. In: *The 40th Conference on Uncertainty in Artificial Intelligence*. 2024. URL: [🔗](#)
- [JC7] Matt-Heun Hong, **Zachary Sunberg**, and Danielle Szafir. “Cieran: Designing Sequential Colormaps with a Teachable Robot”. In: *Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI)*. 2024. DOI: 10.1145/3613904.3642903
- [JC8] **Himanshu Gupta**, Bradley Hayes, and **Zachary Sunberg**. “Intention-Aware Navigation in Crowds with Extended-Space POMDP Planning”. In: *Autonomous Agents and Multi-Agent Systems (AAMAS)*. 2022. DOI: 10.48550/arXiv.2206.10028. URL: [🔗](#)
- [JC9] John Mern, Anil Yildiz, **Zachary Sunberg**, Tapan Mukerji, and Mykel J. Kochenderfer. “Bayesian Optimized Monte Carlo Planning”. In: *AAAI Conference on Artificial Intelligence (AAAI)*. 2021. DOI: 10.1609/aaai.v35i13.17411
- [JC10] **Michael H. Lim**, Claire J. Tomlin, and **Zachary N. Sunberg**. “Sparse Tree Search Optimality Guarantees in POMDPs with Continuous Observation Spaces”. In: *International Joint Conference on Artificial Intelligence (IJCAI)*. 2020. DOI: 10.24963/ijcai.2020/572
- [JC11] **Lasse Peters**, David Fridovich-Keil, Claire Tomlin, and **Zachary Sunberg**. “Inference-Based Strategy Alignment for General-Sum Differential Games”. In: *International Conference on Autonomous Agents and Multiagent Systems (AAMAS)*. 2020. DOI: 10.48550/arXiv.2002.04354. URL: [🔗](#)
- [JC12] **Zachary N. Sunberg** and Mykel J. Kochenderfer. “Online Algorithms for POMDPs with Continuous State, Action, and Observation Spaces”. In: *International Conference on Automated Planning and Scheduling (ICAPS)*. Delft, 2018. DOI: 10.1609/icaps.v28i1.13882. URL: [🔗](#)

Peer Reviewed Conference Publications.....

Peer reviewed conference publications are selected based on peer review of the entire article, but are considered less rigorous and selective than journal-equivalent conference publications.

- [C1] [Under Review] **Himanshu Gupta**, Kelvin Aladum, Bradley Hayes, Nisar Ahmed, and **Zachary Sunberg**. “Beyond Fixed Goal Delivery: Online POMDP Planning for Target Interception in Crowds”. In: *IEEE/RSJ International Conference on Intelligent Robots and Systems (IROS)*. 2026

- [C2] Jiho Lee, Nisar R. Ahmed, Kyle H. Wray, and **Zachary N. Sunberg**. “Rao-Blackwellized POMDP Planning”. In: *IEEE International Conference on Robotics and Automation (ICRA)*. 2025. URL: [🔗](#)
- [C3] Michael Moncton, **Himanshu Gupta**, **Zachary Sunberg**, and Eric Frew. “Autonomous Planning for Targeted Observation of Severe Weather”. In: *Dynamic Data-Driven Application Systems (DDDAS)*. 2024
- [C4] **Zakariya Laouar**, **Qi Heng Ho**, Rayan Mazouz, **Tyler Becker**, and **Zachary N. Sunberg**. “Feasibility-Guided Safety-Aware Model Predictive Control for Jump Markov Linear Systems”. In: *IEEE International Conference on Intelligent Robots and Systems (IROS)*. 2024. doi: 10.1109/IROS58592.2024.10801951
- [C5] Hunter M Ray*, **Zakariya Laouar***, **Zachary N. Sunberg**, and Nisar Ahmed. “Human-Centered Autonomy for UAS Target Search”. In: *IEEE International Conference on Robotics and Automation (ICRA)*. 2024. doi: 10.1109/ICRA57147.2024.10611708
- [C6] Sampada Deglurkar, **Michael H. Lim**, **Johnathan Tucker**, **Zachary N. Sunberg**, Aleksandra Faust, and Claire J. Tomlin. “Compositional Learning-based Planning for Vision POMDPs”. In: *Learning for Dynamics & Control (L4DC)*. 2023. doi: 10.48550/arXiv.2112.09456. URL: [🔗](#)
- [C7] **Qi Heng Ho**, **Zachary N. Sunberg**, and Morteza Lahijanian. “Planning with SiMBA: Motion Planning under Uncertainty for Temporal Goals using Simplified Belief Guides”. In: *IEEE International Conference on Robotics and Automation (ICRA)*. London, England, UK, May 2023. doi: 10.1109/ICRA48891.2023.10160897. URL: [🔗](#)
- [C8] **Benjamin D. Kraske**, Anshu Saksena, Anna L. Buczak, and **Zachary Sunberg**. “Explanation through Reward Model Reconciliation using POMDP Tree Search”. In: *IEEE International Conference on Assured Autonomy (ICAA)*. 2023. doi: 10.1109/ICAA58325.2023.00027. URL: [🔗](#)
- [C9] **Qi Heng Ho**, Roland B. Ilyes, **Zachary Sunberg**, and Morteza Lahijanian. “Automaton-Guided Control Synthesis for Signal Temporal Logic Specifications”. In: *IEEE Conference on Decision and Control (CDC)*. 2022. doi: 10.1109/CDC51059.2022.9993090. URL: [🔗](#)
- [C10] **Qi Heng Ho**, **Zachary N. Sunberg**, and Morteza Lahijanian. “Gaussian Belief Trees for Chance Constrained Asymptotically Optimal Motion Planning”. In: *IEEE International Conference on Robotics and Automation (ICRA)*. 2022, pp. 11029–11035. doi: 10.1109/ICRA46639.2022.9812343
- [C11] **Zachary Nolan Sunberg**, Kathryn Anne Wingate, and Lara Buri. “Fair Senior Capstone Project Teaming based on Skills, Preferences, and Friend Groups”. In: *ASEE Annual Conference*. 2021. doi: 10.18260/1-2--37187. URL: [🔗](#)
- [C12] **Michael H. Lim**, Claire J. Tomlin, and **Zachary N. Sunberg**. “Voronoi Progressive Widening: Efficient Online Solvers for Continuous Space MDPs and POMDPs with Provably Optimal Components”. In: *Conference on Decision and Control (CDC)*. 2021. doi: 10.1109/CDC45484.2021.9683490. URL: [🔗](#)
- [C13] Shakeeb G. Ahmad, **Zachary Sunberg**, and Sean Humbert. “APF-PF: Probabilistic Depth Perception for 3D Reactive Obstacle Avoidance”. In: *American Control Conference (ACC)*. 2021. doi: 10.23919/ACC50511.2021.9482894
- [C14] Ekhlas Sonu, **Zachary Sunberg**, and Mykel J. Kochenderfer. “Exploiting Hierarchy for Scalable Decision Making in Autonomous Driving”. In: *Intelligent Vehicles Symposium*. Changshu, 2018. doi: 10.1109/IVS.2018.8500681
- [C15] **Zachary N. Sunberg**, Christopher J. Ho, and Mykel J. Kochenderfer. “The Value of Inferring the Internal State of Traffic Participants for Autonomous Freeway Driving”. In: *American Control Conference (ACC)*. Seattle, 2017. doi: 10.23919/ACC.2017.7963408. URL: [🔗](#)
- [C16] Patrick Slade, Preston Culbertson, **Zachary Sunberg**, and Mykel J. Kochenderfer. “Simultaneous Active Parameter Estimation and Control using Sampling-based Bayesian Reinforcement Learning”. In: *IEEE/RSJ International Conference on Intelligent Robots and Systems (IROS)*. 2017. doi: 10.1109/IROS.2017.8202242. URL: [🔗](#)
- [C17] **Zachary Sunberg**, Mykel J. Kochenderfer, and Marco Pavone. “Optimized and Trusted Collision Avoidance for Unmanned Aerial Vehicles using Approximate Dynamic Programming”. In: *IEEE*

International Conference on Robotics and Automation (ICRA). Stockholm, 2016. DOI: 10.1109/ICRA.2016.7487280. URL: 

[C18] **Zachary Sunberg**, Suman Chakravorty, and Richard Erwin. "Information space sensor tasking for Space Situational Awareness". In: *American Control Conference (ACC)*. June 2014, pp. 79–84. DOI: 10.1109/ACC.2014.6858922

[C19] **Zachary Sunberg**, Nathaniel Miller, and Jonathan Rogers. "A Real Time Expert Control System for Helicopter Autorotation". In: *70th Forum of the American Helicopter Society*. Montreal, 2014

Conference Publications with Abstract-only Review.....

[A1] **Tyler Becker** and **Zachary N. Sunberg**. "Strategic Satellite Custody Maintenance with AlphaZero". In: *Advanced Maui Optical and Space Surveillance Technologies Conference (AMOS)*. 2025. URL: 

[A2] **Ofer Dagan**, **Tyler Becker**, and **Zachary N. Sunberg**. "Hypothesis-Driven Sensor Tasking for Space Domain Awareness". In: *Advanced Maui Optical and Space Surveillance Technologies Conference (AMOS)*. 2025. URL: 

[A3] **Johnathan Tucker**, **Jackson Wagner**, and **Zachary Sunberg**. "Adaptive Stress Testing Applied To Space Domain Awareness Systems". In: *Advanced Maui Optical and Space Surveillance Technologies (AMOS)*. 2022. URL: 

[A4] **Tyler Becker** and **Zachary Sunberg**. "Imperfect Information Games and Counterfactual Regret Minimization in Space Domain Awareness". In: *Advanced Maui Optical and Space Surveillance Technologies (AMOS)*. 2022. URL: 

[A5] Hunter M. Ray, Nicholas Conlon, **Zachary Sunberg**, and Nisar R. Ahmed. "User Preference Elicitation for Unmanned Aircraft System Collaborative Search". In: *AIAA SCITECH Forum*. 2022, p. 2343. DOI: 10.2514/6.2022-2343

[A6] **Zachary Sunberg** and Jonathan Rogers. "A Fuzzy Logic-Based Controller for Helicopter Autorotation". In: *AIAA Aerospace Sciences Meeting*. Grapevine, 2013. DOI: 10.2514/6.2013-1150

Extended Abstracts.....

[E1] **Tyler Becker** and **Zachary Sunberg**. "Bridging the Gap between Partially Observable Stochastic Games and Sparse POMDP Methods". In: *Autonomous Agents and Multi-Agent Systems AAMAS*. 2025. Submitted as full paper; accepted for presentation as extended abstract (top 40% of full paper submissions)

[E2] **Ofer Dagan**, **Tyler Becker**, and **Zachary N. Sunberg**. "Resolving Multiple-Dynamic Model Uncertainty in Hypothesis-Driven Belief-MDPs". In: *Autonomous Agents and Multi-Agent Systems (AAMAS)*. 2025. Submitted as full paper; accepted for presentation as extended abstract (top 40% of full paper submissions)

Open Source Software

POMDPs.jl [2015 – present]

<https://github.com/JuliaPOMDP/POMDPs.jl>

Interface for defining continuous and discrete, fully and partially observable Markov decision processes along with a suite of state-of-the art solvers written in Julia and C++ [J12]. 33 direct package contributors, 44 dependent packages, 650 GitHub stars, 430 monthly downloads according to juliahub.com.

satisfaculty [2025 – present]

<https://www.satisfaculty.com>

Python package for optimizing teaching schedules using integer linear programming. Used to create Smead AES Fall 2026 schedule.

ProjectAssigner.jl [2020]

<https://github.com/zsunberg/ProjectAssigner.jl>

Software for optimally assigning student teams to projects based on preferences, friend groups, and skills [C11]. Used to assign senior project groups in the AES department from 2020 to 2024.

Research Funding

PI: CAREER: Game-theoretic Online Planning in Partially Observable Domains [2024 – 2029]
National Science Foundation
\$599,985

CU PI: DECODE AI: Deception and Counter-Deception in Artificial Intelligence [2024 – 2028]
Office of Naval Research
\$4,150,000 (total award) | \$1,014,000 (my share); PI: Matthew Hale, Georgia Tech, Co-Is: Ufuk Topku, UT Austin; Ruimeng Hu, UCSB

CU PI: Collaborative Research: Alternative Leaf Water use Strategies in Hot Environments [2023 – 2024]
National Science Foundation
\$944,823 (total award) | \$99,976 (my share), PI: Ben Blonder, UC Berkeley; (I did not participate in securing this grant, but was subcontracted to work on it later.)

PI: Human Centered Autonomy for Dynamic sUAS Target Search Operations [2023 – 2026]
NSF Center for Autonomous Air Mobility and Sensing (CAAMS) Sub-award
\$287,000 (total award) | \$152,000 (my share, approx.); Co-I: Nisar Ahmed, CU Boulder

Co-I: Multi-Phenomenological, Autonomous ... Decision Support [2023 – 2028]
Air Force Office of Scientific Research
\$5,000,000 (total award, approx.) | \$500,000 (my share, approx.), PI: Marcus Holtzinger, CU Boulder; Co-Is: K. Terry Alfriend (TAMU), Scott Palo, Kyle DeMars (TAMU), John Junkins (TAMU), Karen Feigh (Georgia Tech) | Full title: Multi-Phenomenological, Autonomous, and Understandable SDA and XDA Decision Support

Co-I: IUCRC Phase I: Center for Autonomous Air Mobility and Sensing (CAAMS) [2022 – 2027]
National Science Foundation
\$2,210,225 (total award) | \$0 (my direct share - all funds shared for travel and administrative costs), PI: Eric Frew, CU Boulder; Co-Is: Nisar Ahmed, Morteza Lahijanian, and Sriram Sankaranarayanan, CU Boulder; This grant establishes the IUCRC; sub-awards funded through industry contributions are listed separately.

Co-I: Dispersed Autonomy for Marsupial Aerial Robot Teams [2022 – 2025]
National Science Foundation | National Robotics Institute (Collaborative Research)
\$1,045,429 (total award) | \$300,000 (my share, approx.), PI: Eric Frew; Co-Is: Brian Argrow, Adam Houston (University of Nebraska, Lincoln)

PI: HIPPO (Human-Informed Planning with Probabilistic Observations) [2022-2023]
NSF Center for Autonomous Air Mobility and Sensing (CAAMS) Sub-award
\$68,000

CU PI: SURP: Fast planning under uncertainty with operational and safety guarantees [2022-2024]
NASA Jet Propulsion Laboratory
\$180,000 (total award) | \$150,000 (my share), PI: Federico Rossi, JPL; Co-I: Morteza Lahijanian, CU Boulder

CU PI: Elektra: Naval Defensive Resource Allocation through POMDP Optimization [2021 – 2023]
Office of Naval Research (Subcontract of Johns Hopkins University Applied Physics Lab)
\$169,805 | Subcontract on larger award of unknown total amount

Co-I: L3Harris Modern Analytics for Mission Applications (LMA2) [2021-2023]
L3-Harris Technologies
\$1,495,048 (total award) | \$350,000 (my share, approx.), PI: Marcus Holzinger, CU Boulder (I did not participate in securing this grant, but began work on it later.)

CU PI: Full Stack Planning and Control under Uncertainty [2021 – 2022]
NSF Center for Unmanned Aircraft Systems (C-UAS) Sub-award
\$130,000 (total award) | \$65,000 (my share), Co-PI Ella Atkins, Univ. of Michigan

PI: POMDP Algorithms for In-flight Learning in Emergencies [2020 – 2021]
NSF Center for Unmanned Aircraft Systems (C-UAS) Sub-award
\$60,000

Invited Talks and Panels

- [I1] **Technion – Israel Institute of Technology (Online):** “Breaking the curse of dimensionality in POMDPs and games with sampling-based online planning”. 2025
- [I2] **Autonomy Talks Series, Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) (Online):** “Breaking the curse of dimensionality in POMDPs with sampling-based online planning”. 2024. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XDIyX0tanjk>
- [I3] **University of California, San Diego:** “Breaking the curse of dimensionality in POMDPs with sampling-based online planning”. 2024
- [I4] **University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign (UIUC):** “Safe and efficient autonomy in the face of uncertainty”. 2022
- [I5] **University of Texas at Austin:** “Safe and efficient autonomy in the face of uncertainty”. 2022
- [I6] **Korea Advanced Institute of Science and Technology (KAIST) (Online):** “Safe and efficient autonomy in the face of state and interaction uncertainty”. 2022
- [I7] **AIAA Rocky Mountain Annual Technical Symposium:** “Machine Learning in Aerospace Systems”. 2021 (panel)
- [I8] **NASA Jet Propulsion Lab, Pasadena, CA:** “Scalable online POMDP planning for safe and efficient autonomy”. 2021
- [I9] **Johns Hopkins University Applied Physics Lab, Laurel, MD:** “Some Recent Advances in Online POMDP Algorithms”. 2021
- [I10] **SRI International, Palo Alto, CA:** “Safety and Efficiency for Autonomous Vehicles through Online Learning”. 2019
- [I11] **Washington State University, Pullman, WA:** “Safety and Efficiency for Autonomous Vehicles through Online Learning”. 2019
- [I12] **University of Colorado, Boulder, CO:** “Safety and Efficiency for Autonomous Vehicles through Online Learning”. 2019
- [I13] **Renault-Nissan Research, Sunnyvale, CA:** “Safety and Efficiency in Autonomous Vehicles through POMDP Planning”. 2018
- [I14] **Lyft Level 5, Palo Alto, CA:** “Safety and Efficiency in Autonomous Vehicles through Planning with Uncertainty”. 2018
- [I15] **Makani, Alameda, CA:** “Algorithms for Uncertain, Non-convex Control Problems in the Real World”. 2018
- [I16] **Indeed, San Francisco, CA:** “Safety and Efficiency in Autonomous Vehicles through Planning with Uncertainty”. 2018

Other Presentations

- JuliaCon 2021:** “POMDPs.jl and Interactive Assignments in Julia”. 2021
- Julia in Controls Workshop, ACC, Seattle, WA:** “POMDPs.jl”. 2017
- Open Source Software for Decision Making (OSS4DM), Stanford, CA:** “POMDPs.jl - Challenges and Lessons Learned”. 2017

Teaching

At CU Boulder

ASEN 3728/3128 Aircraft Dynamics [Fa 2022, Sp 2024, Sp 2025]

University of Colorado Boulder, typical enrollment: 140

Required Junior-level course in aircraft dynamics, stability, and control.

Team taught with Prof. Eric Frew in 2022.

Open-source course materials: <https://github.com/zsunberg/Aircraft-Dynamics-Materials>

Nominated by students for the 2025 John and Mercedes Peebles Innovation in Education Award

ASEN 5264 Decision Making under Uncertainty [Sp 2020–Sp 2026]

University of Colorado Boulder, typical enrollment: 30-60

New entry-level graduate course about decision making under uncertainty created by me.

Open-source course materials: <https://github.com/zsunberg/CU-DMU-Materials>

Open-source companion software package: <https://github.com/zsunberg/DMUStudent.jl>

ASEN 6519: Optimization: Applications and Algorithms [Fa 2025]

University of Colorado Boulder, typical enrollment: 10-15

New advanced graduate course that surveys optimization techniques created by me.

Open-source course materials: <https://github.com/zsunberg/CU-Optimization-Materials>

ASEN 6519 Advanced Survey of Sequential Decision Making [Fa 2021, Fa 2023, Fa 2025]

University of Colorado Boulder, typical enrollment: 10-15

New advanced graduate course that surveys recent advances in decision making under uncertainty created by me.

ASEN 4018/4028 Senior Design Project [Fa 2020–Sp 2021]

University of Colorado Boulder, typical enrollment: 250-300, team size: 9-12

Capstone senior design course. I mentored two teams and created new optimization-based approach (see Open Source Software) for fairly creating teams based on student preferences [C11].

Prior to CU Boulder

Army High Performance Computing Summer Institute [June 2017]

Stanford University, Stanford, CA

Developed and taught a 5 lecture course about decision making under uncertainty for college students.

Stanford Artificial Intelligence Lab OutReach Summer (SAILORS, now AI4ALL) [2015-2017]

Stanford University, Stanford, CA

Developed and taught a 2 week course and project for high school students that included programming robots for optical line following and using Dijkstra's algorithm to find the shortest path on a road network; only project mentor to serve all three years of the program. <http://ai-4-all.org/>

AA-228/CS-238 Decision Making Under Uncertainty [Autumn 2016]

Stanford University, Stanford, CA

Head course assistant for a class of around 200; developed problems for midterm project; gave guest lectures on the POMDPs.jl framework and autonomous driving research; project software reused at Iowa State University.

Advising and Mentoring

Postdoctoral Scholars

Ofer Dagan [2024 – 2025]

Founding Machine Learning Engineer, Eiro Inc.

Graduated Ph.D. Thesis Advisees

Qi Heng Ho (Co-advised with Morteza Lahijanian) [2020 – 2025]

Assistant Professor, Virginia Tech

Hyun Jae (Michael) Lim (Co-advised with Claire Tomlin at U.C. Berkeley) [2020 – 2023]

AI Scientist, C3.ai

Current Ph.D. Thesis Advisees		
Tyler Becker (Comprehensive exam spring 2026)		[Fall 2020 – Present]
Ben Kraske (Comprehensive exams spring 2026, Received NSF GRFP)		[Fall 2020 – Present]
Zakariya Laouar (Prelim exam fall 2022)		[Fall 2021 – Present]
Himanshu Gupta (Prelim exam fall 2023)	[Fall 2020 (Started as MS) – Present]	
Lisa Ventura (Prelim exam fall 2025)		[Fall 2024 – Present]
Mark Boyer (Prelim exam fall 2025)		[Fall 2024 – Present]
Mel Krusniak		[Spring 2026 – Present]

Graduated M.S. Thesis Advisees		
William Pope		[Spring 2022 – Fall 2022]
<i>U.S. Space Force Officer</i>		

Independent Study Advisees		
Austin Monell		[2023 – 2024]
Johnathan Tucker (Received NSF GRFP under my direction)	[Fall 2020 – Summer 2022]	
Saurabh Mishra		[Spring 2020]

Ph.D. Comprehensive Exam and Defense Committees		
Sangwoo Moon	Aastha Acharya	
Charles (Luke) Burks	Shohei Wakayama	
Neha Garg (Nat. Univ. of Singapore, External Examiner)	Marcus Lapeyrolerie (Univ. of California, Berkeley, Qualls)	
Ramya Kanlapuli	John R. Martin	
Katherine Glasheen	Adam Herrmann	
Andrew Mills	Camron (Alex) Hirst	
Chandrakanth Venigalla	Hunter Ray	
Sam Fedeler	Michael Klonowski	
John Jackson	Mark Stephenson	
Prashin Sharma (Univ. of Michigan)	Michael Moncton	
Shakeeb Ahmad	Matt Budd (University of Oxford)	
John Mern (Stanford Univ.)		

M.S. Thesis Committees		
Lasse Peters (TU Hamburg)	Jamison Mcginley	
Wyatt Raich	Rio McMahon	
Cody Charland	Eli Kravitz	
Akash Ratheesh	Abdoulaye Diallo	

Service		
Co-Organizer of <i>Faculty Sanity</i> University-Wide Happy Hour		[2024–present]
Undergraduate Curriculum Committee		[2024–present]
Onboarding mentor for new faculty member		[2023–present]
Undergraduate Operations Committee		[2023–present]
Optimized undergraduate teaching assignments for course scheduling for the department.		
Autonomous Systems Faculty Search Committee		[2023–2025]
Graduate Program Committee		[2020–2023]
<i>Autonomous Systems Lead</i>		
Served on Preliminary Exam Subcommittee, Revised MS Admissions Criteria		

Outreach and Inclusion

Speaker for Tuskegee Airmen outreach event at CU [2021, 2022, 2025]
Smead aerospace career panelist [2023]
Rising Stars in Aerospace organizing committee member [2022]
Invited Speaker for AIAA Movie Night & Technical Discussion: 2001: A Space Odyssey [2021]

Conference and Workshop Organization

Inference and Decision Making for Autonomous Vehicles (IDMAV) [2023]
Workshop at Robotics: Science and Systems (RSS)
Co-organizer with Christoffer Heckman, Han-Lim Choi (KAIST), and students
Strategic multi-agent interactions: game theory for robot learning and decision making [2022]
Workshop at the Conference on Robotic Learning (CoRL)
Co-organizer with David Fridovich-Keil (Univ. of Texas), Negar Mehr (Univ. of Illinois), and Forrest Laine (Vanderbilt)

Academic Peer Review and Editing

Area chair for Robotics: Science and Systems (RSS) Conference [2025 – 2026]
Guest editor for the AIAA Journal of Aerospace Information Systems [2020 – 2022]

Reviewer: I have reviewed manuscripts for the following journals and conferences:

AAAI Conference on Artificial Intelligence	IEEE Robotics and Automation Letters
ACM Transactions on Mathematical Software	IEEE Transactions on Cybernetics
AIAA Journal of Guidance, Control, and Dynamics	IEEE Transactions on Intelligent Transportation Systems
AIAA Journal of Aerospace Information Systems	IEEE Transactions on Intelligent Vehicles
American Control Conference (ACC)	Intelligent Transportation Systems Conference (ITSC)
American Geophysical Union (AGU) Books	Intl. Journal of Robotics Research (IJRR)
Journal of the American Helicopter Society	Intl. Symposium on Robotics Research
Autonomous Robots	Intl. Joint Conference on Artificial Intelligence (IJCAI)
Artificial Intelligence	Learning for Decision and Control Conference (L4DC)
Journal of Artificial Intelligence Research	Operations Research
Field Robotics	R (programming language) Journal
IEEE Conference on Decision and Control (CDC)	Robotics, Science and Systems (RSS)
IEEE Intl. Conf. on Robotics and Automation (ICRA)	Conf. on Uncertainty in Artificial Intelligence (UAI)
IEEE Intl. Conf. on Intelligent Robots and Systems (IROS)	

Proposal Review

Proposal Reviewer for Israel Science Foundation (ISF) [2026]
NSF Computer and Information Science and Engineering (CISE) Proposal Review Panelist [2023]
Army Research Office (ARO) Proposal Reviewer [2023]

Professional Affiliations

American Institute of Aeronautics and Astronautics (AIAA) Member [~2010-Present]
Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers (IEEE) Member [~2015-Present]